

NESS HERITAGE

User's Guide

Palace of Versailles
Augmented Reality Experience

Follow a luminous pink path through the gardens and halls of Versailles.
Scan landmarks to uncover their stories, listen to narrated histories, and
explore an interactive map of the entire estate.

Table of Contents

- 1. Introduction 3
- 2. About the Palace of Versailles 4
- 3. Getting Started 5
- 4. App Navigation 6
- 5. The AR Tour Experience 7
- 6. Scanning Landmarks 8
- 7. Audio Narration 9
- 8. Interactive Castle Map 10
- 9. Complete Landmarks Catalog 11
- 10. Practical Visitor Information 14

1. Introduction

Welcome to NESS Heritage, an immersive augmented reality application designed to transform your visit to the Palace of Versailles into an unforgettable journey through time. Whether you are walking the grand halls of the palace or strolling through the meticulously manicured gardens, NESS Heritage brings the stories of Versailles to life right before your eyes.

Using your smartphone's camera, NESS Heritage overlays a luminous pink navigation path onto the real world, guiding you from one landmark to the next along a carefully curated tour route. At each stop, you can scan the landmark to receive an AI-generated historical explanation, complete with detailed context, anecdotes, and architectural insights. An integrated audio narration feature reads these explanations aloud, allowing you to absorb the rich history of Versailles without taking your eyes off the magnificent surroundings.

The app also includes an interactive map of the entire estate, showing all scannable points organized by category, with the full tour route displayed as a dashed pink path. You can filter landmarks by type, tap any marker for details, and navigate directly to a landmark's full information page. This guide will walk you through every feature in detail, ensuring you get the most out of your NESS Heritage experience.

2. About the Palace of Versailles

The Palace of Versailles is one of the most magnificent and historically significant royal residences in the world. Originally a humble hunting lodge built by Louis XIII in 1623, it was transformed by his son, Louis XIV (the Sun King), into the grandest palace in Europe — a monument to absolute monarchy and the pinnacle of French classical art and architecture.

Louis XIV began his expansion of Versailles in 1661, and the project continued for over five decades. The palace grew to include more than 2,300 rooms, 2,153 windows, and 67 staircases, spread across an estate of more than 800 hectares of gardens, parks, and outbuildings. The architect Jules Hardouin-Mansart oversaw much of the construction, including the iconic Hall of Mirrors, the Royal Chapel, and the palace's two enormous stable buildings.

The gardens, designed by the landscape architect Andre Le Notre, are considered the finest example of the French formal garden style. They feature over fifty fountains, numerous sculptural groves (bosquets), the Grand Canal, the Orangerie, and an elaborate hydraulic system that was a marvel of 17th-century engineering. Le Notre's design used optical illusions, axial geometry, and carefully orchestrated sequences of views to create a landscape of breathtaking grandeur.

Versailles was the seat of the French court from 1682 until the Revolution of 1789. It was here that Louis XIV established the elaborate etiquette and ceremonial that defined court life, here that Marie Antoinette built her beloved Petit Trianon and the Queen's Hamlet, and here that the Estates-General met in 1789, sparking the Revolution with the famous Tennis Court Oath. Today, Versailles is a UNESCO World Heritage Site and one of the most visited cultural sites in the world, welcoming over eight million visitors annually.

3. Getting Started

System Requirements

NESS Heritage is designed for modern smartphones with a rear-facing camera. For the best AR experience, use a device running iOS 14+ or Android 10+ with a recent browser (Safari, Chrome, or Firefox). Camera access is required for the AR tour features. A stable internet connection is needed for AI-generated content and the interactive map.

Creating an Account

To begin, create a free account using your email address or sign in with Google. Your account allows you to track your tour progress and access personalized features. After registering, verify your email with the OTP code sent to you, and you will be ready to start your Versailles journey.

Camera Permissions

When you first launch the AR Tour, your browser will request permission to access your camera. Tap 'Allow' to enable the augmented reality experience. The app uses your camera to display the live view of your surroundings and overlay the navigation path and scanning interface. Your camera feed is processed entirely on your device and is never recorded or transmitted.

4. App Navigation

NESS Heritage uses a bottom navigation bar that is accessible from every main screen. The navigation bar contains four primary sections:

Home

The landing page featuring a hero image of Versailles, quick-start buttons for the AR Tour and Landmarks, and an overview of the app's key features.

Map

An interactive dark-themed map of the entire Versailles estate, showing all scannable landmarks as numbered, category-colored markers connected by a dashed pink tour route.

AR Tour

The core augmented reality experience. Launches your camera, displays the navigation overlay with a pink path, and provides the scanning interface for each landmark.

Landmarks

A browsable gallery of all landmarks, filterable by category (Interior, Exterior, Gardens, Monuments). Each card shows the landmark's image, name, description, location, and estimated visit time.

Additionally, a User's Guide page is accessible from the Home screen, where you can download this comprehensive PDF document for offline reference.

5. The AR Tour Experience

The AR Tour is the heart of the NESS Heritage experience. When you launch it from the Home screen or the AR Tour tab in the bottom navigation, your camera activates and the augmented reality interface appears.

The Navigation Overlay

Once the camera is active, a navigation overlay appears on screen. At the center of the display, a luminous pink fluorescent path is rendered in 3D perspective, appearing to lie on the ground ahead of you. This path is animated with flowing dashes that move forward, creating a sense of direction and movement. The path adjusts its perspective based on your position, giving the illusion that it extends into the real world ahead of you.

Along the path, pulsing waypoint markers indicate the positions of upcoming landmarks. These markers glow rhythmically, drawing your eye toward the next point of interest. A heads-up display (HUD) at the top of the screen shows your current progress, the name of the next destination, and the estimated distance remaining.

Tour Progress

The tour follows a carefully designed route through the estate, visiting landmarks in a specific order (indicated by tour numbers). As you arrive at each landmark, the scanning interface becomes available. When you finish scanning and learning about a landmark, tap 'Continue to Next Stop' to proceed to the following waypoint. An exit button (X) is always available in the top corner if you need to leave the tour at any time.

6. Scanning Landmarks

When you arrive at a landmark during the AR Tour, a prominent scan button appears at the bottom of the screen. Tapping this button initiates the scanning sequence — a brief animation of a sweeping scan line that simulates the analysis of the landmark in front of you.

AI-Generated Content

Once the scan is complete, NESS Heritage uses an advanced AI language model to generate a detailed, context-aware historical explanation of the landmark. This explanation goes beyond a static description — the AI draws on its knowledge of French history, art, architecture, and the specific landmark to produce a rich, multi-paragraph narrative that covers the landmark's creation, its historical significance, key architectural features, and fascinating anecdotes from the era of the Bourbon monarchy.

The generated content appears in a bottom sheet that slides up from the bottom of the screen. The sheet contains the landmark's name and category, the full AI-generated description (formatted with headings and paragraphs), and a visitor tip specific to that landmark. If the AI service is temporarily unavailable, a fallback description from the landmark's database record is displayed instead.

Closing the Scan Panel

You can close the scan results at any time by tapping the X button in the top corner of the sheet or by tapping the dimmed background. When you are ready to move on, tap 'Continue to Next Stop' to advance to the following landmark. If you are at the final stop, the button reads 'Finish Tour' instead.

7. Audio Narration

NESS Heritage includes a built-in audio narration feature that reads the AI-generated landmark descriptions aloud. This feature is designed for visitors who want to keep their eyes on the magnificent surroundings while absorbing the historical context through audio — particularly useful when standing in front of a landmark and wanting to fully appreciate the view.

How to Use Audio Narration

After scanning a landmark, the results bottom sheet includes a 'Read Aloud' button located between the visitor tip and the continue button. Tapping this button activates the device's text-to-speech engine, which narrates the full historical description in a clear, natural voice at a slightly slowed pace (0.95x speed) for optimal comprehension.

While narration is active, the button changes to 'Stop Audio' with a square icon, allowing you to halt playback at any time. The narration automatically stops when you close the scan panel, continue to the next stop, or navigate away from the page. If speech synthesis is not available on your device (rare on modern devices), the button will have no effect.

Tips for Audio Narration

For the best listening experience, consider using headphones or earbuds, especially in crowded areas of the palace and gardens. The narration works entirely offline using your device's built-in speech engine, so it will function even in areas with poor connectivity. The text is cleaned of markdown formatting before being read, ensuring smooth, natural-sounding speech.

8. Interactive Castle Map

The Interactive Castle Map provides a bird's-eye view of the entire Versailles estate, displaying all scannable landmarks as numbered markers on a dark-themed map. Accessible from the 'Map' tab in the bottom navigation, the map is a powerful tool for planning your visit and navigating between landmarks.

Map Markers

Each landmark is represented by a circular marker showing its tour order number. The marker color corresponds to the landmark's category: gold for Interior, sky blue for Exterior, emerald green for Gardens, and purple for Monuments. Each marker is surrounded by a pulsing animation ring that draws attention to the scannable points. The markers are positioned at the precise GPS coordinates of each landmark.

Tour Route

When the 'All' filter is selected, a dashed pink line connects all the markers in tour order, showing the complete recommended route through the estate. This allows you to visualize the full tour path and plan your walking route accordingly. The polyline follows the tour order, creating a path from the Royal Gate through the palace, gardens, and out to the Trianon palaces.

Filtering and Popups

Filter pills at the top of the map allow you to show only landmarks of a specific category, or all landmarks. Tapping any marker opens a popup with the landmark's name, category, short description, and a 'View details' link that navigates to the full landmark detail page. The map supports standard touch gestures for zooming and panning, and uses a dark CARTO basemap that complements the app's royal aesthetic.

9. Complete Landmarks Catalog

The following pages contain the complete catalog of all 54 scannable landmarks in the NESS Heritage tour, organized by category. Each entry includes the landmark's name, tour stop number, historical period, location, description, and a visitor tip.

Interior Landmarks

3. Royal Chapel (Chapelle Royale)

1710 | North Wing

A breathtaking two-level chapel with a painted ceiling depicting the Holy Trinity and the Resurrection.

Visitor Tip:

The king sat in the royal gallery on the upper level — not at ground level — so he could be seen by the entire court.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

4. King's Grand Apartment

1671–1681 | Central Wing

A suite of seven salons, each dedicated to a classical planet and its associated Roman god.

Visitor Tip:

Each room represents a different planet in the Roman pantheon, all orbiting the sun — Apollo — the symbol of Louis XIV himself.

Estimated visit time: 15 minutes

5. Hall of Mirrors (Galerie des Glaces)

1684 | Central Wing

The most famous room in Versailles — 357 mirrors face 17 arcaded windows beneath a painted vault ceiling.

Visitor Tip:

In the 17th century, mirrors were more expensive than gold. Look for the hidden service doors disguised as mirror panels.

Estimated visit time: 15 minutes

6. Queen's Apartment

1672–1789 | Central Wing

The private chambers of queens from Marie-Thérèse to Marie Antoinette, including the legendary bedroom.

Visitor Tip:

Find the hidden door in the queen's bedroom — Marie Antoinette escaped through it during the October Days of 1789.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

7. Royal Opera (Opéra Royal)

1770 | North Wing

A magnificent wooden theater that could transform into a ballroom for royal celebrations.

Visitor Tip:

The entire auditorium is made of wood, painted to look like marble — creating some of the finest acoustics in Europe.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

12. War Salon (Salon de la Guerre)

1686 | Central Wing

A spectacular salon celebrating Louis XIV's military victories, featuring a stucco relief of France on horseback trampling enemies.

Visitor Tip:

Look up at the ceiling — the central panel shows France armed, seated on clouds, surrounded by conquered enemies.

Estimated visit time: 8 minutes

13. Peace Salon (Salon de la Paix)

1686 | Central Wing

The eastern counterpart to the War Salon, celebrating peace and prosperity under Louis XIV.

Visitor Tip:

This room was redecorated for each queen. The paintings change depending on which queen was in residence.

Estimated visit time: 8 minutes

14. Mercury Salon (Salon de Mercure)

1682 | Central Wing

The king's state bedroom, named after the god Mercury, originally featuring a silver balustrade and silver furniture.

Visitor Tip:

The silver furniture was melted down in 1689 to finance wars. The silver balustrade alone weighed over a ton.

Estimated visit time: 8 minutes

15. Apollo Salon (Salon d'Apollon)

1681 | Central Wing

The royal throne room, dedicated to Apollo the Sun God — Louis XIV's personal emblem and the theme of the entire palace.

Visitor Tip:

The throne sat on a raised platform under a canopy. Notice how the entire room is oriented around the sun motif.

Estimated visit time: 8 minutes

16. Battles Gallery (Galerie des Batailles)

1833 | South Wing

A 120-meter gallery commissioned by Louis-Philippe, depicting 13 centuries of French military triumphs in massive paintings.

Visitor Tip:

Look for the painting of the Battle of Tolbiac — it depicts Clovis, the first Christian king of France, from 496 AD.

Estimated visit time: 15 minutes

47. Théâtre de la Reine (Queen's Theatre)

Louis XVI, 1780 | Petit Trianon Estate

An intimate, exquisitely preserved wooden theater built for Marie Antoinette at the Petit Trianon.

The Théâtre de la Reine, built in 1780 by architect Richard Mique, is a small but exquisitely detailed theater located in the gardens of the Petit Trianon. It was commissioned by Marie Antoinette, who was a passionate devotee of the theater and an accomplished amateur actress.

The theater is a masterpiece of *trompe l'œil*: though it appears to be made of carved stone and gilded marble, the entire structure is constructed of wood, painted with extraordinary skill to mimic more expensive materials. This technique, borrowed from Italian theater design, allowed the queen to have a fully functional theater at a fraction of the cost of a stone building.

The auditorium seats approximately 100 people, arranged in tiers of boxes around a central orchestra. The stage is equipped with sophisticated mechanical effects, including a wave machine, a flying system, and a trap door — all still functional today. The ceiling, painted with clouds and sky, creates the illusion of an open-air theater.

Marie Antoinette performed here regularly, taking roles in plays by Molière and Racine. The theater was a space where the rigid hierarchy of the court was temporarily suspended: the queen could step into other characters, and her courtiers could, for a few hours, see her as something other than their sovereign. The Théâtre de la Reine is one of the best-preserved 18th-century theaters in Europe and is occasionally used for performances to this day.

Visitor Tip:

Look up at the ceiling — the painted clouds and sky are so realistic that you might forget you're indoors.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

50. Galerie des Carrosses (Coach Gallery)

1682–19th century | Grande Écurie (Great Stables)

A magnificent collection of royal carriages, sleighs, and sedan chairs used by French monarchs from Louis XIV to Napoleon III.

The Galerie des Carrosses, housed in the Grande Écurie (Great Stables) across from the palace, contains one of the finest collections of royal carriages in Europe. The gallery includes coaches, berlines, sleighs, and sedan chairs used by French monarchs from the 17th to the 19th century, offering a unique perspective on the material culture of the French court.

Among the highlights is the coronation coach of Charles X, an enormous gilded vehicle weighing over four tons and requiring eight horses to pull. Its body is decorated with painted panels and gilded sculptures representing the virtues of kingship. Equally impressive is the funeral hearse of Louis XVIII, a black-draped carriage of extraordinary somber grandeur.

The collection also includes the berline used by Napoleon I for his wedding to Marie-Louise in 1810, and a variety of sleighs used by the court for winter recreation on the frozen Grand Canal. These sleighs, painted in bright colors and decorated with sculptural groups, reveal a playful side of court life that is often overlooked.

The Grande Écurie itself, designed by Jules Hardouin-Mansart and completed in 1682, is an architectural masterpiece in its own right. Built to house the king's horses and the staff who managed them, it could accommodate up to 600 horses. The building's U-shaped plan and grand facade make it one of the most impressive stable buildings ever constructed.

The Galerie des Carrosses provides a fascinating counterpoint to the palace itself: while the palace shows how the kings lived, the coach gallery shows how they moved. Together, they offer a complete picture of the material world of the French monarchy.

Visitor Tip:

Don't miss the Napoleon III sleighs — they're painted in bright, festive colors and reveal a playful side of royal life rarely seen in the palace.

Estimated visit time: 15 minutes

51. Escalier des Ambassadeurs (Ambassadors' Staircase)

Louis XIV, 1684 (demolished 1752) | Central Wing — North End

The grand ceremonial staircase where foreign ambassadors were received — a breathtaking cascade of marble, fresco, and gold.

The Escalier des Ambassadeurs, designed by Jules Hardouin-Mansart and completed in 1684, was the most spectacular ceremonial space in the palace of Versailles. This grand staircase was the primary route by which foreign ambassadors and dignitaries ascended from the ground floor to the King's Grand Apartment on the first floor.

The staircase was a feast of marble, fresco, and gilding. The walls were clad in colored marbles — red, green, and white — arranged in geometric patterns. The vaulted ceiling, painted by Charles de la Fosse, depicted Apollo surrounded by the signs of the zodiac and the four continents, presenting Louis XIV as the ruler of the universe.

The Escalier des Ambassadeurs was also a political theater. Ambassadors climbing the stairs were made to feel the full weight of French power: each step brought them past sculptures and paintings celebrating the king's military victories and the glory of his reign. By the time they reached the King's apartment, they were meant to be overwhelmed.

Tragically, the staircase was demolished in 1752 by Louis XV, who needed the space for a new apartment for his daughter. The destruction of the Escalier des Ambassadeurs is considered one of the greatest losses in the history of French architecture. Today, visitors can see the void where it once stood, and the lower portion of the staircase, which has been partially restored, giving a sense of the grandeur that was lost.

Visitor Tip:

Though the staircase was largely destroyed in 1752, the remaining lower section and the descriptions give a sense of its overwhelming grandeur — imagine it in its full glory.

Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

Exterior Landmarks

1. Royal Gate (Grille Royale)

1680s | Main Entrance

The monumental golden gateway marking the entrance to the Palace of Versailles.

Visitor Tip:

Look up to see the royal fleur-de-lis crowning the gilded gates — a symbol of the French monarchy.

Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

2. Royal Courtyard (Cour Royale)

1624–1631 | Main Building

The grand stone courtyard where courtiers once gathered, awaiting the king's appearance.

Visitor Tip:

Notice the distinct architectural styles — each facade represents a different building campaign across three reigns.

Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

11. Marble Courtyard (Cour de Marbre)

1623–1668 | Main Building

The original facade of Louis XIII's hunting lodge, decorated with elaborate marble and ironwork patterns.

Visitor Tip:

This is the oldest part of the palace. The black and white marble patterns were inspired by the Tuscan order.

Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

39. Orangerie du Château (The Orangery)

Louis XIV, 1686 | South Wing — Below Palace

A vast vaulted gallery housing over a thousand citrus trees, sheltered beneath the palace's southern terrace.

The Orangerie, designed by Jules Hardouin-Mansart and completed in 1686, is one of the architectural masterpieces of Versailles. This vast vaulted gallery, built into the slope beneath the palace's southern parterre, was designed to shelter the estate's collection of exotic citrus trees during the winter months.

The building is a feat of engineering: its double-arched vaults, rising thirteen meters high, create a cavernous interior that maintains a remarkably stable temperature year-round. The south-facing windows capture maximum sunlight, while the thick stone walls provide thermal mass that keeps the interior cool in summer and warm in winter.

The Orangerie houses over 1,000 trees, including 700 orange trees, as well as lemon, pomegranate, and palm trees. Many of these trees are centuries old — the oldest, known as the 'Grand Bourbon,' was planted in 1421 and was a gift from the King of Spain to Louis XIV. The trees are wheeled out onto the parterre each spring in a ceremonial procession that has remained unchanged for over three centuries.

The gardens in front of the Orangerie, known as the Parterre Bas, feature geometric flowerbeds and a central pool. The entire complex — the building, the gardens, and the view over the south parterre — represents one of the most harmonious ensembles at Versailles, where architecture and horticulture are perfectly integrated.

Visitor Tip:

Visit in spring or autumn when the citrus trees are brought out or taken in — it's a centuries-old ritual that is fascinating to watch.

46. Hameau de la Reine (Queen's Hamlet)

Louis XVI, 1783–1787 | Petit Trianon Estate

Marie Antoinette's storybook rustic village — a cluster of thatched cottages, a mill, and a farm around a peaceful lake. The Hameau de la Reine, or Queen's Hamlet, is perhaps the most extraordinary creation at Versailles: a fabricated rustic village built between 1783 and 1787 by architect Richard Mique for Marie Antoinette. Located in the gardens of the Petit Trianon, the hamlet consists of twelve picturesque cottages, a working farm, a mill, a dairy, and a tower, all arranged around a small artificial lake.

Marie Antoinette created the hamlet as a retreat from the suffocating formality of court life. Here, surrounded by a select group of friends, she could play at being a simple country gentlewoman — dressing in muslin dresses, tending to her animals, and enjoying the pastoral idyll that the philosopher Rousseau had made fashionable.

The hamlet was not merely a stage set: it was a working farm with livestock, vegetable gardens, and a dairy that produced milk and cheese for the queen's table. The cottages, though rustic in appearance, were luxuriously appointed inside, with fine furniture and silk hangings hidden behind thatched exteriors.

The Hameau de la Reine was profoundly controversial. While Marie Antoinette saw it as innocent escapism, her subjects saw a queen playing at poverty while real peasants starved. The hamlet became a symbol of the disconnect between the monarchy and the people, contributing to the revolutionary fervor that would ultimately destroy the Ancien Régime. Restored in the 2000s, the hamlet today offers a fascinating glimpse into the queen's private world.

Visitor Tip:

Don't miss the interior of the Queen's House — the contrast between the rustic exterior and the elegant interior reveals the theatrical nature of Marie Antoinette's retreat.

Estimated visit time: 20 minutes

48. Pavillon Français (French Pavilion)

Louis XV, 1750 | Gardens — Between Palace and Trianon

An elegant garden pavilion where Louis XV dined al fresco, bridging the formal gardens and the new landscape park. The Pavillon Français, built in 1750 by architect Ange-Jacques Gabriel for Louis XV, is an elegant neoclassical pavilion situated at the intersection of the formal gardens and the new English-style landscape park. It was designed as a place where the king could dine al fresco with a small group of courtiers, away from the rigid ceremonies of the palace.

The pavilion is a single-story structure with a central salon flanked by two small cabinets. The facade features four Corinthian columns supporting a pediment, giving it the appearance of a miniature temple. The interior was decorated with painted panels and gilded boiseries in the Rococo style, creating an atmosphere of refined intimacy.

Louis XV used the Pavillon Français for his famous 'dîners d'appartement' — intimate dinners where the king set aside protocol and encouraged his guests to eat freely and converse openly. These dinners were a revelation for courtiers accustomed to the elaborate ceremonies of the royal table, where every gesture was prescribed by etiquette.

The pavilion also served as a transitional architectural element, marking the shift from Le Nôtre's formal geometry to the more naturalistic landscape style that Gabriel and Louis XV favored. It looks out over both the formal gardens and the new English garden, serving as a visual hinge between two different conceptions of landscape design.

Visitor Tip:

The pavilion marks the transition between the formal French gardens and the English landscape park — notice how the garden style changes as you walk past.

Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

52. Cour des Princes (Princes' Courtyard)

Louis XIV, 1680s | North Wing — Ministers' Wing

The courtyard where princes of the blood and high nobles lodged in buildings directly attached to the palace. The Cour des Princes, located on the north side of the palace complex, was the courtyard where princes of the blood royal and other high-ranking nobles were given lodgings. The buildings surrounding the courtyard were known as the 'Ailes des Ministres' (Ministers' Wings) — North and South — and housed not only the apartments of princes and ministers but also the offices and archives of the royal administration.

During the reign of Louis XIV, being granted lodgings at Versailles was one of the highest marks of royal favor. Princes, dukes, and ministers competed fiercely for apartments, and the proximity of one's lodgings to the king's own apartments was a precise measure of one's standing at court. The Cour des Princes was relatively far from the king's private apartments, which meant that the nobles housed here were important but not among the innermost circle.

The courtyard itself is an elegant space, paved with cobblestones and enclosed by uniformly designed facades of cream-colored stone. The architecture is restrained and classical, typical of Hardouin-Mansart's work at Versailles, with regular windows and modest decorative elements.

Today, the Cour des Princes is used for administrative purposes and is less visited than the main palace, but it offers a glimpse into the practical workings of the court — the vast bureaucracy and hierarchy of lodging that kept the machinery of absolute monarchy running.

Visitor Tip:

This courtyard shows the practical side of Versailles — the administrative machinery that kept the court running. It's quieter than the main areas.

Estimated visit time: 3 minutes

Garden Landmarks

8. Versailles Gardens (Jardins du Château)

1661–1700 | *Palace Grounds*

André Le Nôtre's masterpiece of formal French garden design, spanning 800 hectares of orchestrated nature.

Visitor Tip:

The gardens were designed to be viewed from above — stand on the palace terrace for the full geometric effect.

Estimated visit time: 30 minutes

9. Latona Fountain (Fontaine de Latone)

1670 | *Gardens*

A tiered marble fountain depicting the goddess Latona and her children Apollo and Diana.

Visitor Tip:

The fountain tells the story of Latona turning rude peasants into frogs — look for the frog sculptures at the base.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

10. Grand Canal

1668 | *Gardens*

A 1.6 km cross-shaped waterway that served as the grand axis of the gardens and a stage for spectacles.

Visitor Tip:

Louis XIV hosted gondola festivals and miniature naval battles here. The canal reflects the sky perfectly at sunset.

Estimated visit time: 15 minutes

17. Apollo Fountain (Fontaine d'Apollon)

1668 | *Grand Canal*

A dramatic fountain showing the sun god Apollo rising from the water in his chariot, directly symbolizing Louis XIV.

Visitor Tip:

At sunset, the gilded Apollo appears to rise from the Grand Canal — a deliberate alignment that celebrates the Sun King.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

18. Neptune Fountain (Fontaine de Neptune)

1741 | *Gardens*

The largest fountain in the gardens, featuring 99 water jets and statues of Neptune, Amphitrite, and sea gods.

Visitor Tip:

The fountain's water jets were designed to create a surprise — many are hidden and only activate during fountain shows.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

19. The Orangerie

1686 | *South of Palace*

A vast curved greenhouse designed by Mansart, housing over 1,000 trees including orange trees from Portugal and Italy.

Visitor Tip:

The oldest orange trees date back to the 17th century. In winter they are moved inside; in summer they line the parterre.

Estimated visit time: 15 minutes

23. Colonnade Grove (Bosquet de la Colonnade)

1685 | *Gardens*

A circular marble peristyle of 32 Ionic columns surrounding a central fountain, designed by Mansart.

Visitor Tip:

The central fountain depicts Persephone being carried off by Pluto — a mythological scene chosen for its dramatic water effects.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

24. Ballroom Grove (Bosquet de la Salle de Bal)

1702 | *Gardens*

An open-air amphitheater of cascading waterfalls and tiered greenery where court festivities and balls were held.

Visitor Tip:

The waterfall was designed to create music — water flowing over different stones produced varying tones as it fell.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

25. Bassin d'Apollon (Apollo's Basin)

Louis XIV, 1668–1671 | *Gardens — Central Axis*

A monumental fountain where the sun god Apollo rises from the waters in his chariot, heralding the dawn.

The Bassin d'Apollon, constructed between 1668 and 1671, is one of the most iconic fountains in the Versailles gardens. Designed by Jean-Baptiste Tuby after a drawing by Charles Le Brun, the central sculpture depicts Apollo, the sun god, emerging from the waters in a four-horse chariot, symbolizing the rising sun. This was no accident: Louis XIV, the Sun King, identified himself with Apollo, and the fountain served as a powerful allegory of his reign.

The fountain sits at the crossroads of the Grand Canal and the main east-west axis of the gardens, creating a dramatic visual line from the palace. As visitors walk down the Tapis Vert toward the canal, Apollo appears to rise before them, his gilded bronze figures catching the light.

During the reign of Louis XIV, the fountain was surrounded by elaborate sculptural groups representing the seasons. Today, the Bassin d'Apollon remains one of the most photographed features of Versailles, its waters reflecting the sky and surrounding greenery in a scene of timeless grandeur.

Visitor Tip:

Visit at sunrise or sunset when the golden light transforms Apollo's chariot into a blazing spectacle. The fountain operates during the Grandes Eaux Musicales show.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

26. Bassin de Neptune (Neptune Fountain)

Louis XIV–Louis XV, 1679–1739 | Gardens — North End

The grandest fountain in Versailles, featuring Neptune surrounded by tritons, dragons, and water-spouting sea creatures. The Bassin de Neptune, located at the northern end of the gardens, is the largest and most elaborate fountain at Versailles. Its construction spanned over a century, beginning under Le Nôtre in 1679–1681 and completed by Claude Desjardins between 1736 and 1739 under Louis XV.

The fountain features a central statue of Neptune, god of the sea, brandishing his trident. He is surrounded by tritons blowing conch shells, sea gods, and an array of water-spouting dragons and sea creatures. When all the jets are activated, the fountain produces nearly a hundred water effects, creating a dazzling aquatic spectacle.

The Bassin de Neptune was designed as the culmination of the northern water axis of the gardens. Its scale and theatricality reflect the Bourbon monarchy's obsession with water as a symbol of power — the ability to command nature itself.

Today, the fountain's water displays are a highlight of the Grandes Eaux Musicales, drawing crowds who gather along its rim to watch the cascading waters dance to classical music.

Visitor Tip:

Time your visit with the Musical Fountains Show — Neptune's 99 water jets create the most spectacular display in the gardens.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

27. Bassin du Dragon (Dragon Fountain)

Louis XIV, 1667 | Gardens — North Axis

A dramatic fountain depicting a winged dragon being slain by Apollo, perched on a rocky crag above cascading waters. The Bassin du Dragon, situated along the northern water axis of the gardens, was constructed in 1667 under the direction of Le Nôtre. The fountain depicts a winged dragon coiled atop a rocky outcrop, struck by an arrow from Apollo, representing the triumph of light over darkness — a recurring theme in the iconography of Louis XIV, the Sun King.

Below the dragon, a cascade of water tumbles down tiered rocks into a large circular basin, while smaller water jets spray from the surrounding rocks. The sound of the cascading water was deliberately designed to create a sense of drama and movement, enhancing the theatrical experience of walking through the gardens.

The dragon itself is a remarkable piece of bronze sculpture, its scales and wings rendered in meticulous detail. In the 17th century, the fountain was part of a network of water features that told the story of Apollo's battles, creating a mythological narrative that unfolded as visitors strolled along the garden paths.

The Bassin du Dragon remains one of the most beloved fountains for families visiting Versailles, its playful waters and fearsome dragon capturing the imagination of children and adults alike.

Visitor Tip:

Walk around the entire fountain — the dragon looks different from every angle, and the water cascades are best appreciated from the lower path.

Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

28. Bassin de la Pyramide (Pyramid Fountain)

Louis XIV, 1672 | Gardens — North Section

An elegant tiered fountain shaped like a pyramid, with water cascading down three superimposed basins. The Bassin de la Pyramide, located in the northern section of the gardens near the Allée des Marmousets, was designed by François Girardon and completed in 1672. The fountain consists of three superimposed lead basins, each smaller than the one below, creating a pyramid shape that rises from a large circular pool.

Water cascades from the top of the pyramid down through the successive basins, creating a gentle, musical sound that

contrasts with the more dramatic fountains elsewhere in the gardens. The leadwork was originally gilded, and traces of the gold can still be seen on sunny days.

The pyramid form was inspired by Egyptian obelisks and Roman pyramids, reflecting Louis XIV's desire to position Versailles within the tradition of the greatest civilizations in history. The fountain was part of Le Nôtre's carefully orchestrated garden experience, where every element served both an aesthetic and a symbolic purpose.

Girardon, one of the most celebrated sculptors of the era, also created the statue of Pluto abducting Proserpina for the nearby Bosquet de la Colonnade. The Pyramid Fountain is a testament to his ability to combine classical form with the playful element of water.

Visitor Tip:

The pyramid is easiest to photograph in the morning when the light hits the cascading water directly, creating beautiful reflections.
Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

29. Bosquet de la Salle de Bal (Ballroom Grove)

Louis XIV, 1671–1674 | Gardens — North Groves

An open-air amphitheater of cascading waterfalls, designed by Le Nôtre as a natural ballroom for court festivities. The Bosquet de la Salle de Bal, also known as the Cascade Grove, is one of the most enchanting spaces in the Versailles gardens. Created between 1671 and 1674 by Le Nôtre, it was designed as an open-air ballroom where the court could enjoy musical performances and dances surrounded by the sound of falling water.

The grove is laid out as a semicircular amphitheater, with tiers of white marble steps descending toward a central clearing. A monumental cascade of eighty-three water jets descends from the top of the semicircle, creating a shimmering curtain of water that serves as both backdrop and natural music. The sound of the cascade was deliberately tuned to provide a pleasant acoustic backdrop for the musicians and dancers.

At the center of the clearing, a small island once held a platform for the orchestra. The surrounding slopes were planted with dense greenery, creating an intimate, enclosed space that felt worlds away from the grand formality of the parterres near the palace.

The Salle de Bal was a favorite venue of Louis XIV, who hosted lavish garden parties here during the summer months. The grove was meticulously restored in the 2010s, returning its cascades to their original glory and allowing modern visitors to experience the same magical setting that once hosted the fêtes of the Sun King.

Visitor Tip:

Sit on the marble steps and close your eyes — the sound of the cascade creates a natural symphony that has not changed in over 350 years.
Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

30. Bosquet des Trois Fontaines (Three Fountains Grove)

Louis XIV, 1677–1679 | Gardens — North Groves

A intimate grove featuring three terraced fountains at different heights, creating a playful descending water dialogue. The Bosquet des Trois Fontaines, designed by Le Nôtre between 1677 and 1679, is a cleverly designed grove featuring three fountains arranged on descending terraces. Each fountain has a distinct character: the uppermost features jets that shoot straight up, the middle fountain creates a dome of water, and the lowest produces a fan-shaped spray.

The grove was conceived as a place of surprise and delight. Visitors entering through the dense greenery would suddenly encounter the first fountain, then discover the second and third as they descended through the space. The sound of water grows louder and more complex as one moves downward, creating a layered acoustic experience.

Louis XIV was so fond of the Trois Fontaines that he included it in his personal guided tours of the gardens, often surprising visiting dignitaries with the grove's playful water displays. The king's admiration for water features was well known — he reportedly spent the equivalent of billions of euros in today's money on the garden's hydraulic systems.

Restored in 2004, the grove once again allows visitors to experience the descending dialogue of water that Le Nôtre so

carefully orchestrated. The interplay of sound, movement, and hidden discovery makes it one of the most engaging spaces in the gardens.

Visitor Tip:

Walk through the grove from top to bottom to experience the full effect — each terrace reveals a new water display and a new perspective.

Estimated visit time: 8 minutes

31. Bosquet de la Colonnade (Colonnade Grove)

Louis XIV, 1685 | Gardens — North Groves

A circular peristyle of marble columns surrounding a fountain depicting Pluto abducting Proserpina.

The Bosquet de la Colonnade, completed in 1685 by Jules Hardouin-Mansart, is one of the most architecturally sophisticated groves in the Versailles gardens. It replaced an earlier grove designed by Le Nôtre and represents a shift toward a more classical, architectural style in the garden's design.

The grove consists of a circular peristyle of thirty-two marble columns, each crowned with a capital supporting a Doric frieze. The columns are arranged in a perfect circle, creating a shaded walkway around a central fountain. At the center stands François Girardon's masterpiece: a sculpture group depicting Pluto abducting Proserpina, cast in bronze and originally gilded.

The choice of subject was deliberate: the abduction of Proserpina, who was taken to the underworld and returned each spring, symbolized the cycle of seasons and the triumph of life over death. In the context of Versailles, it also reinforced the theme of Apollo (the sun) bringing light and life to the world.

The Colonnade is widely considered one of the finest examples of garden architecture in the French classical style. The interplay of light and shadow through the columns, the sound of water from the central fountain, and the theatrical setting of the sculpture create a space of extraordinary beauty and contemplation.

Visitor Tip:

Walk slowly around the full circle of columns — the view of the central sculpture changes dramatically with each step, and the light filtering through the arches is magical in the late afternoon.

Estimated visit time: 8 minutes

32. Bosquet de la Reine (Queen's Grove)

Louis XVI, 1775 | Gardens — South Groves

A romantic grove originally planted for Marie Antoinette, transformed into an English-style picturesque garden.

The Bosquet de la Reine, originally designed by Le Nôtre in the 1670s as the Labyrinth Grove, was one of the most whimsical spaces in the Versailles gardens. It originally featured a maze of paths populated with thirty-nine painted lead animals representing Aesop's Fables, each accompanied by a fountain and a plaque inscribed with the moral of the story.

In 1775, Marie Antoinette ordered the Labyrinth to be destroyed and replaced with a grove in the new English picturesque style. The formal geometry was replaced with winding paths, irregular lawns, and a more naturalistic planting scheme. A circular basin was installed at the center, surrounded by exotic trees and shrubs.

The transformation of the Bosquet de la Reine reflects the broader shift in taste that occurred between the reigns of Louis XIV and Louis XVI — from the rigid formality of the French classical garden to the romantic naturalism of the English landscape garden. Marie Antoinette's influence on the gardens of Versailles was profound, and this grove was one of her favorite retreats.

Tragically, the grove was heavily damaged by the devastating storm of 1999, which destroyed thousands of trees across the estate. It has since been partially restored, though it retains a more natural, less manicured character than the other groves — a fitting tribute to Marie Antoinette's vision of a more intimate, romantic garden.

Visitor Tip:

This grove feels completely different from the rest of the gardens — take a moment to appreciate the shift from Le Nôtre's formality to Marie Antoinette's romantic vision.

33. Bosquet de l'Étoile (Star Grove)

Louis XIV, 1660s | Gardens — South Groves

A grove centered on a fountain shaped like a star, with radiating paths creating a geometric pattern of light and water. The Bosquet de l'Étoile, designed by Le Nôtre in the 1660s, takes its name from the star-shaped fountain at its center. The grove is laid out with paths radiating outward from the central fountain like the points of a star, creating a striking geometric pattern when viewed from above.

The central fountain features a basin shaped like a sixteen-pointed star, with water jets emerging from each point. The surrounding greenery was originally sculpted into dense walls, creating an enclosed space that felt like an outdoor room. The interplay of water, light, and geometry was quintessentially Le Nôtre — a master of creating spatial drama through the manipulation of natural elements.

The Star Grove was part of Le Nôtre's original plan for the gardens, representing the cosmic order that the Sun King sought to impose on nature. The star motif echoed the celestial symbolism that pervaded Versailles, where Apollo, the sun, and the heavens were recurring themes.

Though the grove has been altered over the centuries, it retains its basic radial layout. It is one of the quieter, less-visited corners of the gardens, offering a peaceful spot for reflection away from the more famous fountains and groves.

Visitor Tip:

This is one of the quieter groves — a perfect spot to sit on a bench and enjoy the peaceful atmosphere away from the crowds.

Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

34. Bosquet des Encelades (Enceladus Grove)

Louis XIV, 1675 | Gardens — South Groves

A dramatic grove featuring a fountain of the giant Enceladus buried beneath rocks, struggling against his fate. The Bosquet des Encelades, created in 1675 by Le Nôtre, is centered on one of the most dramatic sculptures in the Versailles gardens: a fountain depicting the Titan Enceladus, half-buried beneath rocks, desperately trying to free himself. The sculpture, by Gaspard Marsy, captures the agony and defiance of the fallen giant with extraordinary emotional power.

In Greek mythology, Enceladus was one of the Giants who waged war against the Olympian gods. Defeated by Athena, he was buried beneath Mount Etna, where his writhing was said to cause earthquakes and volcanic eruptions. The fountain's central jet, which erupts from the rocks above Enceladus, represents the volcanic fire that continues to burn beneath him.

The choice of this subject was deeply political: Louis XIV saw himself as Apollo, the champion of the Olympian order, and the defeated Enceladus symbolized the enemies of the state — the Fronde rebels who had challenged royal authority during the king's childhood. The fountain was a declaration that rebellion against legitimate authority would be crushed.

The grove itself is laid out as a green amphitheater, with slopes rising around the central fountain, creating a theatrical setting that heightens the drama of the sculpture. It is one of the most emotionally charged spaces in the gardens, where mythology, politics, and art converge.

Visitor Tip:

Read the myth of Enceladus before visiting — knowing the story transforms this from a simple fountain into a powerful political allegory.

Estimated visit time: 8 minutes

35. Bosquet du Dauphin (Dauphin's Grove)

Louis XIV, 1670s | Gardens — North Groves

A charming grove with a dolphin-themed fountain, dedicated to the heir to the French throne.

The Bosquet du Dauphin, created in the 1670s, was named in honor of the Grand Dauphin, Louis XIV's eldest son and heir to the French throne. The grove features a central fountain adorned with dolphin sculptures, symbolizing both the sea and the Dauphin himself — the title 'Dauphin' being the traditional name for the heir apparent to the French crown.

The dolphin motif appears throughout the grove, from the bronze sculptures in the fountain to the carved details on the surrounding stonework. In classical mythology, dolphins were associated with Apollo, who was said to have crossed the sea on the back of a dolphin — further reinforcing the solar symbolism that pervaded Versailles.

The grove was designed as an intimate space for the royal family, with shaded paths and quiet corners where the Dauphin and his siblings could play away from the formality of court life. The surrounding greenery was sculpted into dense walls, creating a sense of enclosure and privacy that was rare in the otherwise public gardens.

Though less grand than some of the other groves, the Bosquet du Dauphin possesses a charm and intimacy that makes it a favorite of garden enthusiasts. The dolphin fountain, with its playful water displays, is particularly appealing to children.

Visitor Tip:

Look for the small dolphin carvings hidden throughout the grove — they are easy to miss but add a layer of playful detail.

Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

36. Parterre d'Eau (Water Parterre)

Louis XIV, 1685 | Gardens — Palace Front

Two vast reflecting pools beneath the palace facade, mirroring the building and sky in a stunning double image.

The Parterre d'Eau, completed in 1685 under the direction of Le Nôtre and Jules Hardouin-Mansart, consists of two enormous rectangular reflecting pools situated directly beneath the garden facade of the palace. These pools serve as a mirror, doubling the visual impact of the palace's architecture and creating one of the most iconic views at Versailles.

The parterre was originally adorned with twenty-four bronze statues representing the rivers of France, the seasons, and the times of day. These statues were removed in the 18th century, but the pools themselves remain, their still waters reflecting the palace's windows, the sky, and the surrounding sculptures in an ever-changing tableau.

Le Nôtre designed the Parterre d'Eau as a transition space between the architecture of the palace and the natural world of the gardens. The reflecting pools create a visual dialogue between building and landscape, each enhancing the other. Standing at the edge of the pools, visitors can see the palace reflected upside-down in the water — a deliberate effect that Le Nôtre used to blur the boundary between reality and reflection.

At night, during special events, the pools are illuminated, creating a magical scene where the reflected palace appears to float in a sea of light. During the day, the play of wind on the water surface creates ripples that distort and reform the reflection, making each moment unique.

Visitor Tip:

Stand at the far end of the pools and look back at the palace — the reflection creates a perfect mirror image that is one of the most photographed views at Versailles.

Estimated visit time: 8 minutes

37. Parterre du Nord (North Parterre)

Louis XIV, 1670s | Gardens — North of Palace

Formal flowerbeds and bronze statues beneath the palace's north wing, representing the seasons and French rivers.

The Parterre du Nord, designed by Le Nôtre and completed in the 1670s, is the formal garden area situated directly beneath the palace's north wing. It features geometrically arranged flowerbeds, gravel paths, and a collection of bronze statues representing the seasons, the elements, and the major rivers of France.

The parterre was designed to be viewed from the palace windows above, particularly from the Hall of Mirrors and the King's Grand Apartment. The geometric patterns of the flowerbeds were intended to create a visual extension of the palace's architecture, blurring the boundary between interior and exterior space.

Among the notable statues in the Parterre du Nord are representations of the Seine, the Loire, and the Rhône — the great rivers of France, personified as classical deities. These statues were part of a broader program of symbolism that presented Louis XIV as the master of all France, its rivers and lands laid out in tribute beneath his windows.

The flowerbeds are replanted seasonally, with spring bulbs giving way to summer annuals and autumn chrysanthemums. This means the parterre looks different throughout the year, offering repeat visitors a constantly changing display of color and form.

Visitor Tip:

View the parterre from the palace windows above — the geometric patterns were designed to be seen from this elevated perspective.
Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

38. Parterre du Midi (South Parterre)

Louis XIV, 1680s | Gardens — South of Palace

Sun-warmed flowerbeds and citrus trees below the Orangerie, offering panoramic views over the south gardens. The Parterre du Midi, completed in the 1680s, is the southern counterpart to the Parterre du Nord. Situated beneath the palace's south wing and adjacent to the Orangerie, it features formal flowerbeds, lemon trees in ornamental tubs, and a broad terrace that offers sweeping views over the southern gardens and the Grand Canal beyond.

The parterre was designed to take advantage of its southern exposure, which provides maximum sunlight and warmth. This microclimate allowed the gardeners to grow exotic plants and citrus trees that would not survive elsewhere on the estate. The lemon and orange trees, in their carved wooden tubs, are moved into the Orangerie each winter and brought back out in spring — a tradition that has continued unbroken for over three centuries.

The Parterre du Midi also features two bronze groups by Pierre Le Gros and Pierre Mazeline: 'The Spinner' and 'The Vintager,' representing pastoral life and the bounty of nature. These statues reflect the idealized vision of rural life that was fashionable at the court of Versailles, where the reality of peasant existence was conveniently ignored.

The terrace at the southern edge of the parterre offers one of the finest views in all of Versailles, with the Grand Canal stretching into the distance and the tree-lined avenues converging toward the horizon.

Visitor Tip:

Climb to the terrace at the south end for the best panoramic view of the gardens and the Grand Canal — it's one of the most breathtaking vistas at Versailles.
Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

40. Pièce d'Eau des Suisses (Swiss Lake)

Louis XIV, 1679–1682 | South Gardens — Beyond Orangerie

An enormous artificial lake dug by Swiss Guards, once the site of naval spectacles and gondola rides. The Pièce d'Eau des Suisses, located just south of the Orangerie, is a vast artificial lake covering approximately 180,000 square meters — one of the largest bodies of water in the Versailles estate. It was created between 1679 and 1682 by expanding an existing pond, with the excavation work carried out by the Swiss Guards, who gave the lake its name.

The lake was part of Louis XIV's ambitious hydraulic program, which sought to create ever more spectacular water features throughout the gardens. The earth excavated from the lake was used to build the terrace of the Orangerie, demonstrating the integrated planning that characterized the Versailles project.

During the reign of Louis XIV, the Pièce d'Eau des Suisses was the site of elaborate naval spectacles, including mock sea battles and gondola processions. The king even maintained a flotilla of Venetian gondolas on the lake, rowed by Italian gondoliers brought to Versailles specifically for this purpose.

Today, the lake is a serene spot, popular with joggers and walkers. Its calm waters reflect the surrounding trees and sky, and the grassy banks provide a peaceful place to rest away from the crowds in the main gardens. The sheer scale of the lake — over 700 meters long — gives a sense of the monumental ambition that drove the creation of Versailles.

Visitor Tip:

This is one of the best spots in Versailles for a picnic — the grassy banks are peaceful and offer beautiful reflections of the sky.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

41. Tapis Vert (Green Carpet)

Louis XIV, 1660s | Gardens — Central Axis

A 330-meter grassy avenue lined with statues, creating a grand processional walk between Latona and Apollo fountains. The Tapis Vert, or Green Carpet, is a 330-meter-long grassy avenue that forms the central axis of the gardens between the Latona Fountain and the Bassin d'Apollon. Created by Le Nôtre in the 1660s, it serves as a grand processional walk, drawing the visitor's eye from the palace toward the Grand Canal.

The avenue is flanked by two rows of elm trees and lined with twenty-four statues and groups of sculptures, representing children, fauns, and mythological figures. These statues, cast in lead and originally gilded, were created by some of the finest sculptors of the era, including Gaspard and Balthazard Marsy, and Pierre Le Gros.

The Tapis Vert was designed as a visual hinge in the garden's layout. From the palace terrace, the avenue appears to compress perspective, making the Bassin d'Apollon seem closer than it actually is — a deliberate optical trick employed by Le Nôtre to create a sense of drama and anticipation.

Walking along the Tapis Vert, visitors experience the garden as Le Nôtre intended: a sequence of reveals and surprises, where each step opens a new vista. The avenue is also one of the best places to appreciate the garden's axial design, with paths radiating outward toward the bosquets and the Grand Canal visible in the distance.

Visitor Tip:

Walk from the Latona Fountain toward Apollo — the perspective tricks Le Nôtre used make the distance seem to shrink as you walk.

Estimated visit time: 8 minutes

42. Fontaine des Saisons (Fountain of the Seasons)

Louis XIV, 1670s | Gardens — North Section

An ornate fountain with four sculptural groups representing Spring, Summer, Autumn, and Winter.

The Fontaine des Saisons, located in the northern section of the gardens near the Parterre du Nord, was created in the 1670s and features four sculptural groups representing the four seasons. Each season is personified as a classical figure surrounded by attributes: Spring as a young woman with flowers, Summer as Ceres with sheaves of wheat, Autumn as Bacchus with grapes, and Winter as an old man wrapped in furs.

The fountain was designed as part of a broader iconographic program that presented Versailles as a microcosm of the natural world, with every aspect of nature — the seasons, the elements, the rivers, the continents — represented in sculpture and water. This program reflected Louis XIV's ambition to create a universal seat of power, where all of nature was brought under the dominion of the Sun King.

The sculptural groups were created by Jean-Baptiste Tuby, François Girardon, and other leading sculptors of the era. The quality of the work is exceptional, with each figure rendered in dynamic, lifelike poses that convey the character of its season. The water jets, arranged around and beneath the sculptures, enhance the sense of movement and life.

The Fontaine des Saisons is one of the most elegant fountains in the gardens, its intimate scale and refined sculpture offering a contrast to the more dramatic displays of the Bassin de Neptune or the Latona Fountain.

Visitor Tip:

Try to identify each season by its attributes — it's like a 17th-century puzzle that makes the fountain come alive.

Estimated visit time: 5 minutes

43. Bassin de Cérès (Ceres Basin)

Louis XIV, 1672 | Gardens — South Section

A graceful fountain statue of Ceres, goddess of agriculture and grain, overlooking the southern gardens. The Bassin de Cérès, created in 1672, features a statue of Ceres, the Roman goddess of agriculture, grain, and the harvest. The sculpture, by Étienne Le Hongre, depicts Ceres wearing a crown of wheat and holding a sickle and sheaves of grain, symbolizing the fertility of the French soil under the benevolent rule of Louis XIV.

The fountain is one of a series of four basins along the southern edge of the gardens representing the seasons, with Ceres representing Summer. The others — Flora (Spring), Bacchus (Autumn), and Saturn (Winter) — form a quartet that encodes the cycle of the agricultural year into the garden's geography.

Ceres was a particularly appropriate figure for Versailles, as she embodied the agricultural abundance that was the foundation of France's wealth and power. Louis XIV's ministers worked tirelessly to promote French agriculture, and the inclusion of Ceres in the garden program was a celebration of these efforts.

The basin itself is a simple circular pool, with the statue rising from the center on a small pedestal. Water jets surround the base, creating a gentle spray that catches the light. The Bassin de Cérès is a quiet, contemplative spot, less visited than the major fountains, and offers a peaceful place to sit and enjoy the garden's atmosphere.

Visitor Tip:

Combine your visit with the nearby Bassin de Flore and Bassin de Saturne to see the full cycle of seasons represented in sculpture.
Estimated visit time: 3 minutes

44. Bassin de Flore (Flora Basin)

Louis XIV, 1672 | Gardens — South Section

A delicate fountain statue of Flora, goddess of flowers and springtime, gracing the palace's south gardens. The Bassin de Flore, created in 1672 by sculptor Jean-Baptiste Tuby, features a statue of Flora, the Roman goddess of flowers and springtime. The sculpture depicts Flora as a graceful young woman scattering flowers from her lap, symbolizing the arrival of spring and the renewal of nature under the reign of the Sun King.

The fountain is one of the seasonal basins along the southern gardens, representing Spring in the quartet that includes Ceres (Summer), Bacchus (Autumn), and Saturn (Winter). Together, they form a calendar of stone and water that marks the eternal cycle of the seasons.

Flora was a popular figure in Renaissance and Baroque art, representing not only the beauty of flowers but also the fleeting nature of youth and beauty — a theme that resonated deeply at the court of Versailles, where youth and beauty were currency. The statue's delicate pose and flowing drapery are characteristic of Tuby's style, which combined classical idealism with a French sensibility for elegance and refinement.

The basin is located near the Parterre du Midi, where the warm southern exposure means that flowers bloom here earlier than elsewhere in the gardens — a fitting tribute to the goddess of spring. The water jets surrounding the statue create a delicate mist that, on sunny days, produces small rainbows in the spray.

Visitor Tip:

Visit on a sunny morning — the water spray around Flora creates beautiful little rainbows that are perfect for photography.
Estimated visit time: 3 minutes

53. Allée des Marmousets (Marmousets Walk)

Louis XIV, 1660s | Gardens — North Axis

A charming garden path lined with statues of children and dwarves, connecting the northern fountains of the gardens. The Allée des Marmousets is a picturesque garden path running along the northern section of the Versailles gardens, connecting several of the northern fountains and groves. The path takes its name from the 'marmousets' — small

sculpted figures of children and dwarves that originally decorated the path's fountains and niches.

The walk was laid out by Le Nôtre in the 1660s as part of the northern water axis of the gardens. It runs parallel to the main east-west axis, providing a quieter alternative route through the gardens. Along the path, visitors encounter a series of small fountains, basins, and sculptural groups, each with its own character and story.

The marmousets themselves were a beloved feature of the 17th-century garden. These whimsical figures, cast in lead and painted in bright colors, represented children, fauns, and dwarves engaged in various activities — fishing, playing instruments, tending animals. They added a note of playfulness and humor to the otherwise formal and grandiose garden.

The Allée des Marmousets is one of the most pleasant walks in the gardens, offering shade in summer and a sense of discovery as each turn reveals a new fountain or sculpture. It is less crowded than the main axis, making it a favorite of garden enthusiasts who want to explore Versailles at a more leisurely pace.

Visitor Tip:

Take this path instead of the main axis for a quieter, more charming walk through the gardens — you'll discover fountains and statues most visitors miss.

Estimated visit time: 8 minutes

54. Bassin de Saturne (Saturn Basin)

Louis XIV, 1672 | Gardens — South Section

A fountain statue of Saturn, god of time and winter, completing the seasonal quartet of the southern gardens.

The Bassin de Saturne, created in 1672 by sculptor François Girardon, features a statue of Saturn, the Roman god of time, agriculture, and winter. The sculpture depicts Saturn as an old man holding a scythe, symbolizing both the passage of time and the dormant season of winter when the earth rests beneath the cold.

The fountain is the fourth in the seasonal quartet of the southern gardens, representing Winter alongside Flora (Spring), Ceres (Summer), and Bacchus (Autumn). Together, these four fountains form a cosmological calendar embedded in the landscape, encoding the cycle of the seasons into the very geography of the gardens.

Saturn was a complex figure in classical mythology: associated with time, decay, and the Golden Age, he embodied the paradox that within endings lie new beginnings. In the context of Versailles, Saturn's placement at the southern edge of the gardens — farthest from the palace — may have been intended to suggest that time and winter are kept at bay by the power of the Sun King, whose warmth and light dominate the central axis.

The Bassin de Saturne is a quiet, contemplative spot, its waters gently playing around the figure of the aged god. It is less visited than the major fountains, making it a peaceful place to reflect on the passage of time and the enduring beauty of the gardens that Saturn, in his role as god of time, has watched over for over three centuries.

Visitor Tip:

This is the quietest of the four seasonal fountains — a good place to end your tour of the southern gardens and reflect on the cycle of seasons.

Estimated visit time: 3 minutes

Monuments

20. Grand Trianon

1687 | *Trianon Estate*

Louis XIV's pink marble retreat from court etiquette, set in its own perfumed gardens of flowers and orange trees.

Visitor Tip:

The pink marble columns are real — Louis XIV ordered the stone from quarries in the Pyrenees for this single building.

Estimated visit time: 20 minutes

21. Petit Trianon

1768 | *Trianon Estate*

A refined neoclassical château given to Marie Antoinette as her private refuge from the rigid rituals of court life.

Visitor Tip:

The dining table could be raised through the floor from the kitchen below, so Marie Antoinette could eat without servants present.

Estimated visit time: 20 minutes

22. Queen's Hamlet (Hameau de la Reine)

1783 | *Trianon Estate*

Marie Antoinette's rustic village with a farmhouse, mill, and gardens — a pastoral fantasy far from palace life.

Visitor Tip:

The queen played at being a shepherdess here, complete with perfumed sheep. The farmhouse was staffed by real farmers.

Estimated visit time: 25 minutes

45. Temple de l'Amour (Temple of Love)

Louis XVI, 1778 | *Petit Trianon Estate*

A delicate white marble rotunda on an island, built for Marie Antoinette in the gardens of the Petit Trianon.

The Temple de l'Amour, completed in 1778 by architect Richard Mique, is a small, exquisite rotunda of white marble situated on a tiny island in the middle of a artificial lake in the gardens of the Petit Trianon. It was commissioned by Marie Antoinette as part of her transformation of the Trianon estate into a private retreat from court life.

The temple consists of twelve Corinthian columns supporting a domed roof, with a statue of Cupid carving his bow from Hercules' club at the center. The statue, by Edmé Bouchardon, was originally made for the gardens of the Château de Choisy and was moved to the Petit Trianon at Marie Antoinette's request.

The Temple de l'Amour epitomizes the Marie Antoinette aesthetic: intimate, romantic, and deliberately picturesque. Unlike the grand formality of the main gardens, the temple is approached by winding paths that reveal it gradually, each turn presenting a new, perfectly framed view. The reflection of the temple in the surrounding water adds to its dreamlike quality.

Marie Antoinette was known to row out to the temple in the evenings, enjoying the solitude and beauty of the setting. Today, it remains one of the most romantic spots at Versailles, its white marble columns glowing in the late afternoon light. The temple is visible from the Petit Trianon's garden facade, creating a visual axis that connects the queen's private world to this idealized vision of love.

Visitor Tip:

Walk all the way around the lake — each angle offers a different, perfectly framed view of the temple. Late afternoon light is

magical.

Estimated visit time: 8 minutes

49. Jeu de Paume (Royal Tennis Court)

Louis XIV, 1686 | Royal Courtyard

The indoor court where the Tennis Court Oath was sworn in 1789, igniting the French Revolution.

The Jeu de Paume, built in 1686 by Jules Hardouin-Mansart, is an indoor court for the game of 'jeu de paume' — an early form of tennis that was wildly popular at the court of Versailles. The building is a long, narrow hall with high windows and a vaulted ceiling, designed to provide the specific acoustics and lighting required for the sport.

Louis XIV was an avid player, and the Jeu de Paume at Versailles was one of the finest in France. The king played regularly, and the court was also used for tournaments that drew the best players in the country. The sport was so popular that the term 'devoir de paume' — the obligation to play tennis — was a recognized part of court life.

But the Jeu de Paume's historical significance far transcends sport. On June 20, 1789, the deputies of the Third Estate, locked out of their regular meeting place, assembled in the Jeu de Paume and took the famous Tennis Court Oath, pledging not to disband until they had written a constitution for France. This moment is widely regarded as the birth of the French Revolution and the end of absolute monarchy.

Today, the Jeu de Paume houses a museum dedicated to the Revolution. The empty hall, with its simple architecture and profound historical resonance, is one of the most moving spaces at Versailles. A painting by Jacques-Louis David, commemorating the Tennis Court Oath, dominates one wall — though it was never completed, its unfinished state adds to its emotional power.

Visitor Tip:

This is where the French Revolution effectively began. Stand in the center of the room and imagine the 577 deputies raising their hands in the Tennis Court Oath.

Estimated visit time: 10 minutes

10. Practical Visitor Information

Getting to Versailles

The Palace of Versailles is located approximately 20 kilometers southwest of Paris. The easiest way to reach the palace is by RER C train from central Paris (stations include Saint-Michel, Musée d'Orsay, and Invalides), arriving at the Versailles Château-Rive-Gauche station in about 40 minutes. Alternatively, SNCF trains depart from Paris Montparnasse to Versailles Chantiers, or from Paris Saint-Lazare to Versailles Rive-Droite. From any of these stations, the palace is a 10-15 minute walk. Parking is available near the palace for visitors arriving by car.

Opening Hours

The palace is open Tuesday through Sunday, from 9:00 AM to 6:30 PM (last admission at 6:00 PM). The gardens are open daily from 8:00 AM to 8:30 PM. The park (including the Grand Canal and Trianon palaces) is open daily from 7:00 AM to 8:30 PM. The estate is closed on Mondays and on certain French national holidays (January 1, May 1, December 25). The Musical Fountains Show and Musical Gardens have specific schedules — check the official Versailles website for current dates and times.

Tickets

Several ticket options are available. The 'Palace Ticket' includes access to the Hall of Mirrors, King's Grand Apartment, and Royal Chapel. The 'Passport' ticket includes the palace, gardens, Trianon palaces, and the Queen's Hamlet. On days of the Musical Fountains Show, a specific passport including the show is required for garden access. We strongly recommend purchasing tickets in advance through the official Versailles website, as same-day tickets can sell out, particularly during peak season (April through October).

Accessibility

The palace offers wheelchair access to most areas, with elevators and ramps available. Wheelchairs can be borrowed free of charge at the entrance (subject to availability). The gardens, due to their historic design with gravel paths and multiple levels, present challenges for wheelchair users and strollers. The Trianon palaces and Queen's Hamlet have limited accessibility. Visitors with reduced mobility can request assistance at the entrance. Audio guides are available in multiple languages, and tactile tours can be arranged for visually impaired visitors.

Photography

Photography is permitted throughout the palace and gardens for personal, non-commercial use. Flash photography is prohibited inside the palace to protect the artworks and furnishings. Tripods and selfie sticks are not permitted inside the palace buildings. When using the NESS Heritage AR Tour, feel free to take photos through the camera view — the app does not interfere with your device's native camera functionality.

Best Times to Visit

Versailles is busiest during the summer months (June-August) and on weekends. For a more peaceful experience, visit on a weekday morning, arriving when the palace opens at 9:00 AM. The gardens are particularly beautiful in spring (April-May) when the flowers are in bloom and in autumn

(September-October) when the foliage changes color. If possible, plan your visit on a day of the Musical Fountains Show to see the gardens' water features in operation — this is when Versailles is at its most spectacular. Allow at least a half day for the palace and a full day for the complete estate including the gardens, Trianon palaces, and Queen's Hamlet.

NESS Heritage — Explore the splendor of Versailles through an immersive augmented reality tour, featuring guided pathfinding and interactive historical scans. This guide was generated dynamically and includes all landmarks available at the time of download.